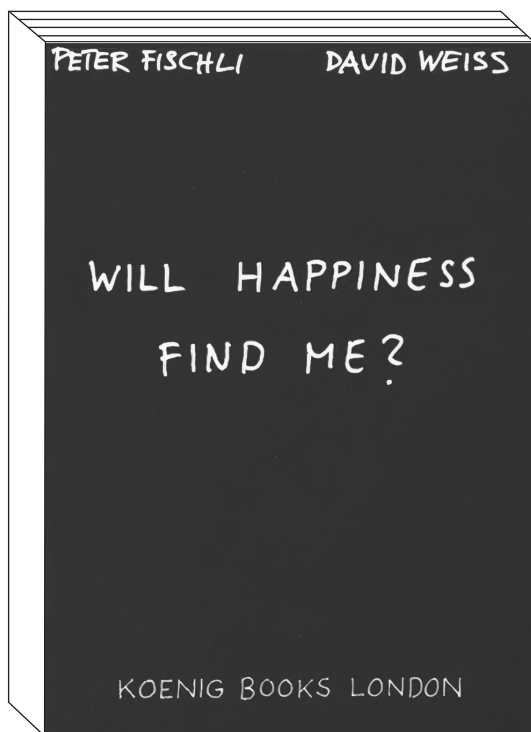




QUESTIONS TO HELP YOU GET STARTED

OR: HOW TO MAKE A RESEARCH PLAN

Unlike the creation of a work of art or design, which could be understood as asking a particular question – however big or small, essential or seemingly off-topic this question might be – the research process may lead you to ask all sorts of questions that aren't necessarily relevant to your process, as you work your way towards an explicitly defined main question. Sometimes, asking as many different questions as possible is precisely the point of the process – as it was for one of my students, who wrote a thesis consisting solely of questions. Similarly, a long-term work by **Peter Fischli and David Weiss**, consisting of a growing collection of all sorts of questions (and appropriately called **Questions**) was eventually exhibited as an installation and published in book form. These works

APPENDICES

↳ QUESTIONS TO HELP YOU GET STARTED

▶ See: *Authorship*,
Referencing,
Copyright, p. 62

▶ See: *Synopsis*, p. 34,
and *Abstract*, p. 36

underline how, when venturing out into new directions, all kinds of questions will pop up, and it can be hard to stay focused on what propelled you to go out into new territory in the first place.

While you can write all these questions down, use them in your work, or find ways to ignore them and stay focused, it will be helpful to keep returning to your key research question – or, if you haven't found it yet, to keep returning to a number of questions that can help you get there. The following are adaptations of questions formulated by my colleague Merel Boers; the fifth question we borrowed from the artist Cornelia Sollfrank. To paraphrase Merel Boers: [▶] these questions are meant to help you get started – or, later in the process, to help you keep track of where you are. You should be able to answer all of these questions in no more than half of an A4-sized page of text, in clear, unambiguous language. There are no wrong answers; only progressively sharper ones. You should thus continuously update your answers and keep track of them in a research plan, synopsis, or working abstract.

[▶] This process can help you to formulate a research question, as well as a preliminary position with regard to this question.

- ↳ What is the narrowest, most precise topic you are researching?
- ↳ Why do you wish to explore this topic?
- ↳ How is this topic related to your previous work, your discipline, the work of your peers, your graduation profile and/or your department?
- ↳ What do you hope to find out?
- ↳ How do you plan to conduct your research?
- ↳ Which methods are you using and/or do you intend to use?
- ↳ What have you already discovered? Was this something you expected?

RULE 1: Find a place you trust, and then, try trusting it for awhile.

RULE 2: (General Duties as a Student) Pull everything out of your teacher. Pull everything out of your fellow students.

RULE 3: (General Duties as a Teacher) Pull everything out of your students.

RULE 4: Consider everything an experiment.

RULE 5: Be Self Disciplined. This means finding someone wise or smart and choosing to follow them. To be disciplined is to follow in a good way. To be self disciplined is to follow in a better way.

RULE 6: Follow the leader. Nothing is a mistake. There is no win and no fail. There is only make.

RULE 7: The only rule is work. If you work it will lead to something. It is the people who do all the work all the time who eventually catch onto things. You can fool the fans – but not the players.

RULE 8: Do not try to create and analyze at the same time. They are different processes.

RULE 9: Be happy whenever you can manage it. Enjoy yourself. It is lighter than you think.

RULE 10: We are breaking all the rules, even our own rules and how do we do that? By leaving plenty of room for “x” qualities.